

FIRST CUSTOMER

First Customer — 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers — Day 1: Target Customer and Buying Trigger

Study guide · Self-study

10 Days to Your First Paying Customers · Day 1: Target Customer and Buying Trigger

How to Use This Guide

This is Day 1 of 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers. It is a working guide, not a textbook. Keep it open beside you and write as you go. The ideas here only pay off when they are applied to your own business, with your own customers and prospects.

- Read each section once, then stop and complete the short exercise before moving on.
- Write your answers in your own words. Short and plain beats polished.
- Complete the What Would You Say? exercises before you look at the Model Answers at the end. The models are examples, not scripts.
- Finish the Upskill Challenge before Day 2. It happens in your own business, with real prospects.
- Set aside about 45 minutes for the full guide, plus the challenge.

> **NOTES**
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> If you only have 15 minutes today, read Target Customer and Buying Trigger, then do the Upskill Challenge. The Challenge is where the learning sticks.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

By the end of this guide you will have moved from a vague market to a named person with a named trigger, and you will have a ranked shortlist of real prospects built on evidence rather than hope.

- Knowledge: You will know the difference between a market, a buyer and a user, and you will know what a buying trigger is and why it decides when a sale can happen.
- Attitude: You will stop trying to sell to everyone and accept that a narrow, specific target is what makes the first sale possible.
- Skill: You will be able to write a one-sentence target customer definition that includes a buying trigger, and to spot early adopter traits in real prospects.
- Upskill: You will apply the early adopter traits to five real prospects, rank them, and choose the three to contact first, then note what your ranking told you about your target definition.

> **NOTES**
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> Write your five prospects down before you rank them, or the ranking will quietly bend toward whoever is easiest to reach.

Introduction: Why the First Customer Needs a Name

Your first paying customer is not a demographic. It is a person who has a problem right now, has the means to fix it and is actively looking for a way. When founders say their market is "small businesses" or "people who want to get fit," they are describing a category wide enough to hide every real buyer in it. A category cannot pay you. A person can.

There is a reason founders stay vague. A broad market feels safe. If you name one specific person, you might be wrong, and being wrong stings. So the instinct is to keep the door open to everyone. That instinct costs you the sale. A message built for everyone reads as relevant to no one, and a prospect who does not feel seen in the first five seconds stops reading.

So today you narrow. You pick one person, describe the moment they start looking, and check that your description matches people who actually exist and actually buy.

- Write down the market you usually describe when someone asks what you do. Just write it plainly, no polishing.
- Write down the last person who actually paid you, or the closest person to that, as a single human being: what they do, what was going on in their life or business.
- Put the two side by side. The gap between the category and the person is what today closes.

> **NOTES**
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> Most founders can describe their market in one confident sentence and struggle to describe a real buyer in detail. That struggle is the useful signal.

Buyers, Users and the People in Between

Before you can name your buyer, separate the roles. In B2B, the person who uses your product is often not the person who signs the check. The team member who struggles with the old process feels the pain daily. The owner or budget holder decides whether money moves. In B2C, the person with the problem may not be the person paying: a parent pays for a child's tutoring; a caregiver buys for an elderly relative.

The buyer, not the user, is the person you must be able to name, speak to and ask to pay. Choosing the wrong person wastes your best conversations. You will spend a call with someone who loves your idea and then watch nothing happen.

The psychological trap is what the user gives you: fluency and enthusiasm. The user will talk freely because they feel the pain, and their approval feels like progress. But approval is not authority. The buyer's hesitation is quieter and more practical. It sounds like "who else has used this?" or "what does it actually cost us in time?" That is the voice you need to reach.

> **NOTES**
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> A common mistake: building the target around the user because they are friendlier and easier to reach. Friendly conversations that never reach the buyer are a comforting way to avoid the sale.
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> - For your own business, name the user and the buyer separately.
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> - If they are the same person, write "same person" and note why in your case (for example, the owner is also the operator).
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> - If they are different, write one sentence about what each one cares about most.
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> - Decide which of the two you will build your target definition around today.

The Buying Trigger: The Moment They Start Looking

A buying trigger is the event or moment that turns a background problem into an active search. Everyone has problems; triggers are why some of them become purchases this month and the rest wait forever.

The trigger is often a change, not a feeling. In B2B it might be a new contract that doubles volume, a key employee leaving, a software renewal notice, or a compliance deadline the customer mentioned openly. In B2C it might be a move, a new baby, a repair estimate, or a season that makes an outdoor job start.

Why does a trigger matter so much? Because buyers act on urgency, not on interest. A customer evaluating your offer next to a third option, when they could also do nothing, is asking one silent question: "Why now?" If you can describe the moment their searching begins, you can answer that question before they ask it. You can also tell a real prospect from a browser. Someone in the middle of a trigger will usually tell you so. Their situation explains their urgency without you having to create any.

There is a second reason to define it. Your target is not just who buys, but who buys now. A perfect-fit customer with no trigger will keep meaning to get back to you. A slightly less perfect-fit customer in the middle of a trigger will pay this week.

> **NOTES**
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> Practice example: a B2B founder sells scheduling software to dental practices. The interest is broadly spread across every practice in town. The trigger is narrower: a practice bringing on a second practitioner, because the paper diary breaks at exactly that size. The founder now looks for hiring notices, not for dental practices in general.
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> - List three to five moments when someone's need for what you offer becomes urgent enough to look for help.
> - For each moment, ask: does the person have money available, and can they decide alone or almost alone?
> - Circle the trigger you can name most confidently. You will use it to write your target definition in the next section.
> - Write one line on what your offer makes possible that was not possible before, given that trigger. This becomes the reason your contact is relevant, which you will develop further on Day 3.

Early Adopter Traits: Spotting the First Customers Most Likely to Buy

Not every customer who needs what you sell will buy from a founder they have never heard of. Your first paying customers are the ones with the fewest reasons to wait. They share four traits. Look for a customer who feels the problem now, has already tried a workaround, has budget or authority, and accepts an imperfect early product. A customer with all four is an early adopter: the person most likely to hand you money before you have a reputation, a polished product or a long track record. This set of traits is closely related to what Steve Blank calls an earlyvangelist in The Four Steps to the

Epiphany (2005): a customer who has the problem, knows they have it, has tried to solve it, and has the budget to act.

Why does this matter so much? Your first sale is a risk for the customer. An unknown founder has no proof, no reviews and no history. Most people avoid that risk without thinking about it. Early adopters handle the risk differently. They feel the problem so sharply that the cost of waiting is higher than the risk of trying you. Their existing workaround is not working. They can pay without asking anyone. And they care more about solving the problem than about having the perfect version.

Day 4 covers how to test these traits in conversation. Today you learn to look for them before the conversation starts.

> **NOTES**
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> A common mistake: mistaking a friendly customer for an early adopter. Friendliness costs nothing. Feeling the problem now, having tried something, and being able to pay are what predict a sale.
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> - Practice example, B2B: A founder sells scheduling software to clinics. Two clinics are interested. Clinic A mentions it might look at scheduling tools next year. Clinic B has an owner who runs the front desk, an office manager taking bookings on paper, a second practitioner starting next month, and a budget line already spent on an outside answering service. Clinic B feels the problem now, has a workaround (paper plus the answering service), has authority and budget, and will accept a first version that only handles bookings. Clinic B is the early adopter.
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> - Practice example, B2C: A founder sells home organizing services. Two people are interested. Person A says they would love to organize the house some day. Person B has just moved, has boxes in the living room, has already tried a storage unit and a weekend of sorting, and has money set aside from the move. Person B accepts that you are new and the first session may be imperfect. Person B is the early adopter.
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> - For each trait, ask: does this person show it now? If you cannot see at least three of the four, treat them as a future customer and move on.
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> - Use the four traits to filter your current list before your next call or email.

Worked Examples

Read both cases and notice how each founder shrinks a category into a named buyer with a named trigger. Also notice what each one had to give up.

- Practice example, B2B: A founder sells a bookkeeping service for software firms. Broad version: "startups." Narrow version: the operational lead or co-founder at a software company with five to fifteen staff, shortly after they win a larger customer who requires cleaner invoicing and reporting, and one to three months before a tax filing. The trigger is visible because the customer announced the contract. The founder now asks, "Who signed a larger customer in the last quarter?" The service is not cheaper than an in-house bookkeeper. It reduces a set of specific tasks around a contract and a deadline.
- Practice example, B2C: A founder sells home organizing services. Broad version: "busy professionals." Narrow version: the adult who has just moved house and still has unopened boxes, whose partner is pushing to get the place liveable, and who is replacing something they

used to handle alone. The trigger is the move. The founder stopped advertising to "busy people" and started asking about what was packed last and not yet needed.

- The two cases share a structure: role or situation, plus a moment in time, plus what they need to solve to move on. Write your own in that same three-part shape.
- Practice example: a target in the three-part shape. "The operations lead at a ten-person software firm who has just signed a customer that requires formal invoicing." It has a role, a moment and a consequence. It is also a person you can picture calling.

> **NOTES**
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> Notice that the narrow version does not reduce the number of possible customers to one. It gives you a way to recognize the ones who are ready, so your first calls and emails land on people who already have a reason to answer.

Apply It in Your Role

You run your own business, so this applies immediately: there is no one else to approve the target, and no internal audience to satisfy. You are the one who calls people, so you will feel the difference in the first conversation.

- Write your target definition in one sentence: who they are, what they are in the middle of, and what becomes possible for them afterward.
- Pick one place where these people are visible during the trigger (a hiring notice, a review, a community, a conversation with someone who already knows them). You will go deeper on Day 2; today simply name where they appear.
- Write the early adopter trait you can check before contacting each prospect, and where you will see it.
- Rewrite your usual self-introduction so a stranger inside your target would recognize themselves in it within a few seconds.

> **NOTES**
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> If your sentence is longer than about 25 words, it is probably still hiding a category. Cut the adjectives and keep the situation.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you look at the Model Answers. Keep the principles general: do not name a real person or repeat anything confidential. The principles matter more than the exact words, and your version should sound like you.

- A founder tells you their market is "anyone with a small business." A friendly prospect has just said, "That sounds useful, keep me in mind." What do you do next, and why?

- A prospect you like a lot is warm, replies to every message and says your service sounds ideal. When you ask, they cannot name a moment when the need became urgent, they have never tried to fix it themselves, and they would have to ask a relative before spending anything. What do you do with this prospect this week, and why?
- A business owner says, "I love it," but their office manager made the actual decision last time. How do you find the buyer without going around anyone?
- You have two good prospects. One fits your definition perfectly but has no trigger. The other fits well and is in the middle of a clear trigger. Who gets your time this week, and how do you say it to the other one?
- Two prospects describe almost the same problem in almost the same words. The first has read about solutions and says they will sort it out one day. The second has built a spreadsheet and a reminder system to cope with it, and is already frustrated with both. Who is closer to buying from you, and what do you ask next?

> **NOTES**
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> Question 2 and question 5 are both traps for the same instinct: counting warmth or a well-described problem as buying evidence. Look for what the person has already done, not how much they seem to like you.

Key Takeaways

These are the ideas to carry into every conversation this week.

- A market cannot pay you. A named person in a named situation can.
- The buyer decides; the user feels. Build your target around the person who signs.
- A buying trigger is an event or moment, not a feeling. It explains "why now" without any pressure from you.
- Early adopters are the customers most likely to pay you first, because they feel the problem now, have already tried a workaround, can pay, and accept an imperfect first version.
- Narrowing does not reduce your opportunities. It is how you recognize the people who are ready.

Quiz

Answer all five questions. Write your answers down before checking the key in Model Answers.

1. What makes a target customer useful for a first sale?

   A. It covers a large enough segment to be worth pursuing

   B. It names a specific person, their situation, and the moment they start looking

   C. It matches the categories in your industry

   D. It includes everyone who could benefit from your offer

2. A founder sells to dental practices. Which is the buying trigger?

   A. The practice exists in their town

   B. The practice has a website

   C. The practice is hiring a second practitioner and the current paper booking system breaks at that size

   D. The owner has mentioned an interest in digital tools

3. A founder sells scheduling software. Clinic A says it might look at tools next year. Clinic B has a second practitioner starting next month, an office manager booking on paper, and a budget line already paying for an outside answering service. Which clinic is the early adopter, and why?

   A. Clinic A, because it has shown interest in the category

   B. Neither, because a founder with no track record cannot sell to clinics yet

   C. Clinic B, because it feels the problem now, already pays for a workaround, and can decide and pay itself

   D. Clinic B, because it is the larger clinic of the two

4. A user and a buyer are different people in a B2B deal. Who should your target definition be built around?

   A. The user, because they feel the problem daily

   B. Whoever replies to your email first

   C. The buyer, because they can decide and pay, while the user's enthusiasm can mislead you

   D. The person with the smallest budget requirement

5. Which of these is the strongest sign of an early adopter?

   A. They say your offer sounds ideal and ask you to keep them in mind

   B. They reply to every message quickly and seem to like you

   C. They describe a problem in almost the same words as another prospect

   D. They have already built a spreadsheet and a reminder system to cope, and are frustrated with both

Upskill Challenge

Do this in your own business before Day 2. It takes about an hour in total across the conversations you already plan to have.

- Write your target definition in one line: who they are, what they are in the middle of, what becomes possible.
- List five real prospects by name, not a category: people or businesses you could contact this week.
- Score each prospect against the four early adopter traits: feels the problem now, has already tried a workaround, has budget or authority, accepts an imperfect first version. Give one point per trait shown now.
- Write the scores as a ranked shortlist, highest first.

- Pick the top three and write what specifically earned each one its place, using the traits rather than a general feeling.
- Note how many of the three came from your own network, and note who else in your target these people resemble. This is your starting point for Day 2.
- At the end of the week, answer two questions in writing: which part of my target definition held up, and which part needs to change?
- Note your next step for Day 2: the one place you will go looking for people inside your trigger.

> **NOTES**
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> Score on evidence you can point to, not on how friendly someone was. Friendly prospects with two traits tend to stay friendly and never pay.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts, and your version should sound like you. Each one is followed by why it works.

- 1. "I would stop and narrow my own definition, then check it against people who actually bought. 'Anyone with a small business' is a category, not a buyer. Before I talk to them again, I want one sentence about the person and the moment that makes my offer useful. 'Keep me in mind' is a sign that my relevance was too vague, not that they loved it." Why it works: it treats the polite reply as information about your targeting, not about your offer.
- 2. "I would treat this person as a future customer, not a buyer, and stop spending my best hours on messages. Warmth and fast replies cost them nothing. They cannot name a moment when the need became urgent, they have never tried to fix it themselves, and they would have to ask a relative before spending. So I would send one honest line: 'I don't think now is the right moment for you, and I may be wrong. I'll check back when something changes on your side.' Then I would move my time to prospects in the middle of a trigger." Why it works: it scores the prospect on what they have done, not how much they like you, and it leaves the door open without pretending there is a sale today.
- 3. "I would say: 'Last time, your office manager was part of the decision, so I want to make sure we build this with both of you rather than around anyone.' Then I would ask the owner directly: 'Would you like the office manager to join our next conversation, or would you rather cover it together with them later?' I would not contact the office manager first to get around the owner. If the owner says yes, I ask the office manager's name and set up a time that suits both." Why it works: it protects the decision process and keeps the buyer in control, and the person who actually decided is included by the owner's choice rather than behind their back.
- 4. "The one in the middle of a trigger gets this week, because their situation makes them ready to decide. To the other one: 'You fit what I do well. I don't think now is the right moment, and I could easily be wrong. Would it help if I checked back in a few weeks?'" Why it works: effort goes where action is possible, while the perfect-fit customer is treated honestly and kept warm by their own choice.

- 5. "Both describe the same problem, but only one has done something about it. The second is closer to buying. They built a spreadsheet and a reminder system, so they have already spent their own time trying to fix this, and they are frustrated with the result. That is past behavior, not a future intention. What I would ask next: 'Walk me through the spreadsheet. What does it do well, and what still slips through?' Then: 'When was the last time it failed you, and what did that cost you?'" Why it works: a workaround the customer built themselves is the clearest evidence of an active search, and their description of where it fails tells you in their own words where your offer fits.
- Quiz answer key:
- 1: B. A useful target names a specific person, their situation and the moment they start looking, not a broad segment.
- 2: C. The trigger is the event that makes the need urgent: hiring a second practitioner breaks the paper booking system at that size.
- 3: C. Clinic B feels the problem now, already pays for a workaround, and can decide and pay itself.
- 4: C. Build the target around the buyer, who can decide and pay, because the user's enthusiasm feels like progress but is not authority.
- 5: D. A workaround the customer built and is now frustrated with is past behavior, the strongest sign of an active search.

> **NOTES**
>
> Check your reasoning, not your wording. Score on evidence you can point to, not on how friendly someone was.

References

- Blank, S. (2005). The Four Steps to the Epiphany. K&S Ranch.